

Kamikaze tactics

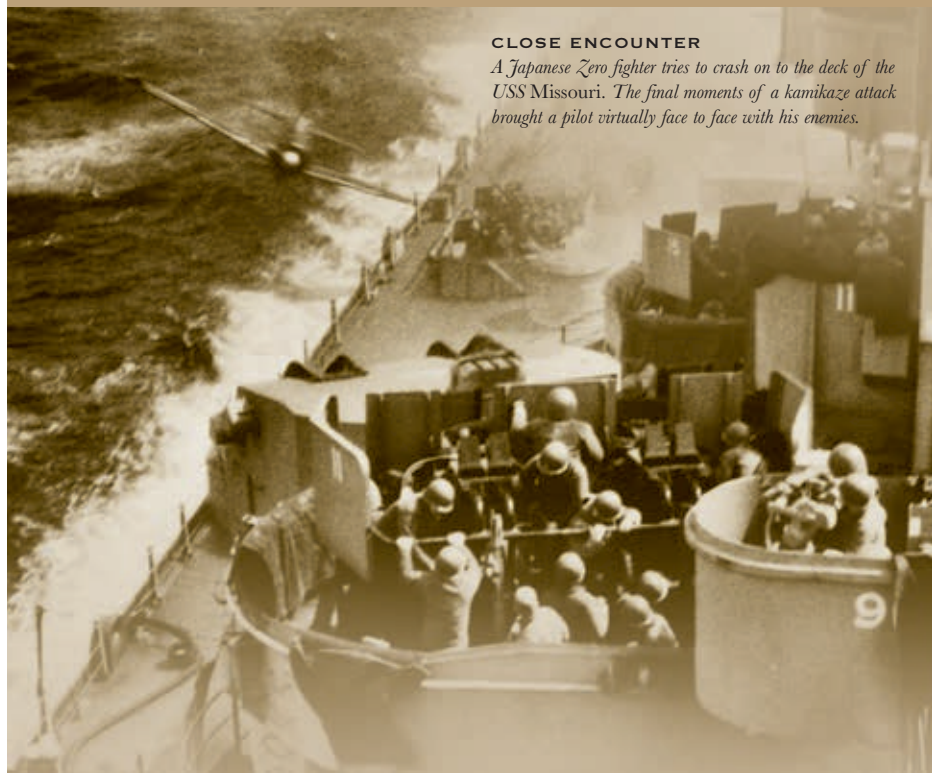
It was during the Battle of Leyte Gulf that Japanese naval airmen first adopted kamikaze tactics. On October 19, 1944, Admiral Takijira Ohnishi, commander of the First Air Fleet, suggested to commanders based at Mabalacat airfield in the Philippines that “the only way of assuring that our meager strength will be effective to a maximum degree” would be “to organize suicide attack units... with each plane to crash-dive into an enemy carrier.” Twenty-six pilots enthusiastically volunteered to form the first “special attack unit.” They were dubbed *kamikaze* (“divine wind”) after a typhoon that had miraculously saved Japan from Mongolian invasion in the 13th century.

Nothing was spared in the effort to bolster morale in men effectively condemned to death. Ohnishi assured them that they were “already gods, without earthly desires.” A ritual was improvised just before takeoff: the kamikaze pilots drank a glass of water or sake, sang a traditional martial song, and donned the *hachimaki* headband once worn by the samurai. Thus encouraged, they went off to die for the emperor. On October 25, a kamikaze pilot crashed a Mitsubishi Zero through the flight-deck of the escort carrier *St. Lo*, dowsing the hangars in burning gasoline that ignited stored ammunition. Ripped apart by a violent explosion, the *St. Lo* sank within an hour. It was a notable success for Japan amid abject failure. Over the following months, kamikaze tactics were adopted throughout the now land-based Japanese naval air force and the army air force.

There was a clear military logic to turning their aircraft into manned, guided missiles. Technologically inferior to the Americans and forced to throw poorly trained pilots into battle, the Japanese could see no other way of reaching and hitting their targets. Japan’s airmen had been flying off in their hundreds to die for the emperor without inflicting the slightest damage on the US fleet. Now they would still die, but not in vain. Kamikaze pilots were presented as an elite who proved through their sacrifice the superiority of the Japanese warrior spirit even in defeat.

The reality was different. As soon as kamikaze attacks became a general tactic, it was obvious that suicide missions would be an absurdly quick way of using up the limited number of experienced pilots. Inevitably, the suicide planes were entrusted to second-raters, dispensable and in more plentiful supply. The experienced pilots flew escort, using their skills to fend off the American fighters. So even in the early days, when suicide attacks were carried out by small groups of aircraft, the kamikaze pilot was hardly a member of an elite force.

FIGHTING THE KAMIKAZES



CLOSE ENCOUNTER

A Japanese Zero fighter tries to crash on to the deck of the USS Missouri. The final moments of a kamikaze attack brought a pilot virtually face to face with his enemies.

“THE JAPANESE AIRCRAFT DIVED THROUGH a rain of steel. It had been hit in several places and seemed to be trailing a banner of flame and smoke, but it came on, clearly visible, hardly moving, the line of its wings as straight as a sword. The deck was deserted; every man, with the exception of the gunners, was lying flat on his face. Flaming and roaring, the fireball passed in front of the ‘island’... The entire vessel was shaken, some forty yards [35m] of the flight deck folded up like a banana skin...” This was the terrifying reality of being on the receiving end of a kamikaze attack, in this case a hit on the carrier *Enterprise*, described by George Blond.

The damage a kamikaze inflicted was often extreme because of the combination of the aircraft’s impact, the explosion of its bombload, and burning aviation fuel. To meet this menace, in the words of US pilot Jimmy Thach, “we needed to have more than a good air defense; we had to have a completely airtight defense.” The number of fighter aircraft on carriers was increased, at the expense of bombers, and combat air patrols were kept in the air over the outer line of destroyer pickets, ready to intercept intruders. A careful watch was kept on returning aircraft, because kamikaze pilots would try to sneak through the defenses with them. A system of “blanket air patrols” was instituted, to keep American aircraft over Japanese airbases almost around the clock, making it impossible for them to launch sorties.



LOW-LEVEL APPROACH

A Nakajima B6N Tenzan (Jill) torpedo-bomber flies in to attack a US carrier through heavy antiaircraft fire – the splashes in the water are made by American naval gunfire.

But some Japanese aircraft always got through, and then it was up to the navy gunners to bring them down. The Japanese pilots practiced all the tricks of any bombing attack on warships – for example, a pair coming in one high one low, to divide the antiaircraft fire, or attacking simultaneously from different directions. The problem for the American gunners was, of course, that unless the Japanese airplane was completely destroyed or rendered uncontrollable, even if it was thoroughly shot up, the kamikaze pilot would still be able to complete his mission.